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You Don't Need a Travel Agent — You Need an Advisor

A conversation with Ali Raymer on launching an agency, advocacy over booking, and marketing every trip.

Host Jeremy Rivera sits down with Ali Raymer — former Title I English teacher, nine-year travel veteran, and founder of Peace and Pearl Travel Co., launched the very week of this recording.

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Ali: peaceandpearltravel.com · The show: unscriptedsmallbusiness.com

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A NOTE FROM THE SHOW

Ali Raymer launched her own travel agency the same week we recorded this — nine years after a chance nudge pulled her out of a Title I English classroom and into the trade. This companion distills the conversation into the seven ideas most worth stealing, whether you're building a service business, rethinking your value in the AI era, or just wondering what a travel advisor really does.

CHAPTER 01

Agent vs. advisor — booking is easy, advocacy is the job

Put on the spot for an elevator pitch, Ali subverts it: you don't need a travel agent. Between AI, Expedia, Booking.com and the Southwest app, the mechanical act of booking has never been easier — and that's exactly the point. What's scarce isn't the booking; it's the judgment and the advocacy around it.

She calls herself “like a marriage counselor,” redirecting clients whose stated wish (Santorini off TikTok, an Italy honeymoon) doesn't match their real style — often landing them somewhere better, like Portugal instead of Italy. And when a trip goes sideways, she's the independent advocate in your corner: during COVID cancellations, direct bookers fought airlines alone while her clients had someone fighting for them. A client stuck finding a rental car in Greece got a quick text back instead of an unanswerable Expedia phone line.

CHAPTER 02

A hot take: regulate advisors like realtors

To explain the role, Ali likens a travel advisor to a realtor — and that analogy sets up her hot take: the industry should be more regulated. Unlike realtors, travel agents need no individual licensing and no continuing education. Anyone can join a host agency, use its license number, and start booking.

“Either Disney is getting that extra 10% commission or a small business owner like myself is. And we’re advocating for you on your behalf instead of a Disney travel agent advocating for, let’s be honest, Disney’s behalf.”

— Ali Raymer

Her advice to consumers is blunt: interview anyone claiming to be a travel agent. She notes ASTA encourages a “blue check mark”—style verification (essentially one simple class), and says she’d happily do continuing ed for the added credibility — because plenty of people in the business love to travel but aren’t always going to be there to pick up the phone when you have a problem.

CHAPTER 03

The host agency as an outsourced back office

Ali is refreshingly clear about what she's not: financials are “a hundred percent not my skill set.” She's the creative visionary who doesn't like spreadsheets, so she deliberately built her agency on top of a host agency that supplies the back-end financial and licensing infrastructure.

That means she doesn't have to build clearing authority from scratch — the host handles much of the money plumbing (“we're gonna make sure you get paid every two weeks”), she operates as an S corp, and a local company runs her payroll. The lesson generalizes: outsource the layer that isn't your superpower so you can spend your time where you actually create value.

CHAPTER 04

How advisors actually get paid

The revenue model is twofold. First, planning and consult fees plus retainers — charged on custom, complex trips, and often waived for something simple like an all-inclusive honeymoon. Second, commissions, driven by consortium and host-agency relationships and by product loyalty: sell more of a product and you earn a higher commission rate.

“Like I literally sell memories and experiences. So I just don’t think there’s a better industry. I really don’t.”

— Ali Raymer

Across the mix, the rough average yield lands around 12%. Crucially, on many products — Disney, cruises — using an advisor costs the client nothing extra, because the supplier pays that commission whether or not a human helped. As Ali frames it, that money is going to someone either way; better it goes to an advocate who works for you.

CHAPTER 05

Points without cutting out the advisor

Ali plays the points game herself — two kids, traveling roughly once a month — so her advice is practical. Pick a card that fits your style, and start with airlines, because flights are what she least wants to pay for out of pocket. Then factor in your local airport; she's near Nashville (BNA), where Southwest runs a strong schedule.

The myth she wants to kill is that loyalty points and a travel advisor are mutually exclusive. For an avid Marriott client she'll build the entire trip loaded with Marriott stays, let him book those himself to burn points and save money, and still earn her commission on the boutique hotels and experiences she manages. Do the points, play the game — and keep the advisor.

CHAPTER 06

Marketing is the industry's biggest gap

Ali's target market splits neatly: Instagram for the millennials and Gen X moms scrolling, Facebook for the retired boomers with money and time. And she calls it imperative to use free social-media marketing on every single trip — she travels about once a month and turns each trip into a marketing moment tuned to what her clients want to know.

“If I went to the gym and looked at my trainer and he didn't have muscles, I wouldn't go to that gym. But he's buff. He looks good. So I'm like, I need to do the same. I need to be exercising my travel muscle.”

— Ali Raymer

This is the biggest gap she sees other advisors leave on the table, and her gym analogy nails why. An advisor who doesn't post their own travels is a personal trainer with no muscles. Travel, she insists, is the easiest thing in the world to talk about and sell — so the advisors who stay quiet are simply forfeiting their best free channel.

CHAPTER 07

AI is already sending her clients

The discovery shift is not theoretical for Ali — it's already in her inbox. Where clients used to say they found her on Google, in the last year they increasingly say they found her through AI search: "I asked Gemini and you came up, you were the first one." Even her traditional boomer parents use it now.

Her takeaway for any small business: don't think only SEO-minded, think about what AI is going to be looking for. The channels are changing under everyone's feet, and the advisors and owners who adapt their visibility to answer engines — not just search results — are the ones who'll keep showing up first.

IDEAS WORTH STEALING

Seven takeaways

- 01** Sell the relationship, not the booking — anyone can book; few will advocate.
- 02** Position with an analogy your buyer already trusts (advisor = realtor).
- 03** Outsource what isn't your superpower — a host agency can be your back office.
- 04** Know your own economics: ~12% yield, two revenue streams, loyalty drives the rate.
- 05** Don't fight the points game — design the trip around it and still get paid.
- 06** Market from lived proof: post every trip, or you're a trainer with no muscles.
- 07** Optimize for AI discovery, not just Google — clients already find you there.

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